

By NARESH TREHAN

A ROADMAP FOR A **HEALTHIER** NATION

THE SCALE OF OUR HEALTHCARE CHALLENGES IS IMMENSE. FOR A 'SWASTHA, VIKSIT BHARAT', INDIA MUST STRIVE TOWARDS A CREATIVE USE OF TECHNOLOGY, PREDICTIVE PRECISION MEDICINE, BIG DATA AND PUBLIC-PRIVATE PARTNERSHIPS

The year 2025 marks an important moment in India's pursuit of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). A decade has passed since these ambitious targets were set, and our journey so far tells a story of progress and persisting challenges. We have made significant strides in reducing mortality rates and expanding healthcare access. But meeting the core targets of SDG-3, which is reducing premature deaths from non-communicable diseases and ensuring universal health coverage, requires innovative solutions and renewed commitment.

The healthcare landscape we face in 2025 is more complex than ever and signals a shifting disease burden that will shape our health priorities for a 'Viksit Bharat' in 2047. Our achievements are notable—infant and maternal mortality rates have improved three- to fourfold since Independence, over 90 per cent of the population stands immunised against common diseases, and life expectancy has doubled to 70 years. However, we confront an evolving disease burden that demands immediate attention and innovative solutions. NCDs (non-communicable diseases) now cause 66 per cent of all deaths, up from 45 per cent in 2000, with diseases of the circulatory system accounting for 32 per cent of medically certified deaths. The National Family Health Survey data help understand the duality of India's nutritional challenges that have evolved beyond undernourishment to include rising obesity and widespread micronutrient deficiencies, even in children. This trend is particularly pronounced in urban areas, where changing lifestyles and dietary patterns have accelerated the premature onset of diabetes, hypertension, cardiovascular diseases and even certain cancers in people in their 30s and 40s.

Climate change is fundamentally reshaping disease patterns across India. Disease vectors now survive in previously unaffected areas, including colder Himalayan regions, bringing malaria, dengue and Japanese encephalitis to new communities. The impact is evident in changing seasonal patterns—dengue cases, which traditionally peaked in September, now peak in November as more regions become suitable breeding grounds for longer periods. This shift in disease patterns, combined with changing patterns of virus transmission from animals to humans, creates new challenges for disease surveillance and control while raising the threat of future pandemics. By 2047, this epidemiological trajectory, combined with India's elderly population (set to hit 21 per cent by then) is projected to inflate our overall disease burden significantly.

The scale of our healthcare challenges is immense. By 2047, India will need 3.4 million physicians, a sharp increase from our current 0.7 physicians per 1,000 people. This change must be supported by an army of caregivers, including nurses and ASHAs, to ensure healthcare reaches the last mile. The infrastructure demands are equally challenging: 2.4 million additional hospital beds will be needed